

force—our professions to behave more like businesses. Rather, we ought to be encouraging companies and corporations (the enterprises that create products and services) to regain the professional values that so many of them have cast aside. We have more than enough of the fool's gold of marketing and salesmanship and not enough of the real gold of trusteeship and stewardship. And we think more like managers, whose task is to do things right, than as leaders, whose task is to do the right thing.

In life, we too often allow the illusory to triumph over the real. We focus too much on *things* and not enough on the *intangibles* that make things worthwhile; too much on *success* (a word I've never liked) and not enough on *character*, without which success is meaningless. Amidst the twenty-first-century pressures for immediate satisfaction and amassing information on demand, we've forgotten the enlightened values of the eighteenth century. We let false notions of personal satisfaction blind us to the real sense of calling that gives work meaning for ourselves, our communities, and our society.

Socrates' Challenge

When I make these points in forums around the country, I sometimes feel like one of those sign-wielding *New Yorker* cartoon prophets ("Repent, for the end is near!"). While my message is hardly in the mainstream—and generally ill received by those in charge of our corporate and our financial institutions—the message is nothing new. Consider that 2,500 years ago, Socrates had much the same message to deliver in his challenge to the citizens of Athens.

I honor and love you: but why do you who are citizens of this great and mighty nation care so much about laying up the greatest amount of money and honor and reputation, and so little about wisdom and truth and the greatest improvement of the soul? Are you not ashamed of this? . . . I do nothing but go about persuading you all, not to take thought for your